2 | The History of Indo-Pakistani Conflict

The spread of nuclear weapons to South Asia has long been the subject of intense international concern. This concern has arisen from two major factors. First, India and Pakistan have a long, bloody history. The two countries were born out of a partition of British India in 1947. Muslims, Hindus, and Sikhs fled from those regions of the empire that would become parts of India and Pakistan. In the spate of Hindu-Muslim violence that followed, 500,000 to 1 million people were killed and roughly 15 million were displaced.[1] The bulk of this violence occurred in the state of Punjab.[2]

Partition left a legacy of animosity between India and Pakistan that continues to the present day.[3] And the division of the subcontinent gave rise to bitter territorial disputes that have festered for decades.[4] The conflict over control of the territory of Kashmir has been especially intractable, giving rise to four Indo-Pakistani wars as well as to a low-intensity conflict between Pakistani proxies and Indian security forces.[5] Kashmir continues to be the primary source of regional tension and would be the likely cause of any future Indo-Pakistani conflict.

The origins of the Kashmir dispute can be traced to the process of British colonial disengagement from the subcontinent. The two principal nationalist movements in British India, the Indian National Congress and the Muslim League, had failed to reach any accord on power sharing under the aegis of a united India. The League asserted that Congress, despite its espousal of the cause of secular nationalism, was unable to guarantee the rights of Muslims in a predominantly Hindu polity.[6] In the 1940s, the British made some belated efforts to preserve the unity of their subcontinental empire.